

HUMAN RIGHTS



MOST OF US BELIEVE that as human beings we have certain rights – to say what we want, to be treated fairly, and not be discriminated against because of our gender, colour, age, religion, sexual orientation, or ethnic group. These and other rights are human rights we carry with us wherever we live. In many countries, these rights are written into national law, but in others they are denied. Recently, world attention has focused on countries that deny their citizens basic human rights. Despite this, abuses of human rights are still common.

Bills of Rights

Many countries have incorporated a declaration of human rights into their constitutions. In France, for example, the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen, written in 1789, today forms part of the constitution of the French Republic.

The US Bill of Rights

The first ten amendments to the US Constitution constitute the US Bill of Rights. It includes the right to freedom of worship, the right to bear arms, and the Fifth Amendment (the right to remain silent to avoid self-incrimination); witnesses took this in the 1950s to protect themselves against investigations into "un-American activities".



Taking the Fifth Amendment, 1950s



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Freedom of expression

The right to express your views without fear of censorship or persecution, for example, in speaking against a government, is a fundamental human right. But it is denied in some countries, where newspapers and television are heavily censored, and people are not allowed to demonstrate or express their views in public.

Amnesty leaflet against censorship

Civil rights

Civil rights are those rights that people enjoy in individual countries and that are protected by law. Civil rights include basic human rights, as well as political rights such as the freedom to join a trade union. Where civil rights are denied, popular movements may be formed, committed to repair the injustice.



Minority rights

The law is often used unfairly against certain groups of people whose culture has minority status within their society. Ethnic, religious, and other minorities have all had to protest in order to receive the rights already enjoyed by the majority of the population.

As a minority, homosexuals have had to campaign for equal civil rights in many countries.

Justice is often symbolized as a blindfolded figure, holding a pair of scales.



A fair trial is a basic human right.

What are human rights?

Human rights are those rights and privileges which people possess, regardless of the country they live in. Basic human rights include the right to freedom of speech, political liberty, and religious freedom.

Some people believe that the right to the necessities of life, such as

food and clean water, should also be viewed as basic human rights. These are often lacking in areas of severe poverty.



Clean water

Modern human rights

The horrors of world war and countless atrocities in the 20th century have led people to believe that the only way to protect human rights is by setting an international standard to which all countries agree. Since 1945, many international agreements have been signed to protect the rights of oppressed people around the world.

Universal Declaration

In 1948, the United Nations passed a Universal Declaration of Human Rights to serve as "a common standard of achievement for all peoples and all nations". American Eleanor Roosevelt (1884–1962), chair of the UN Commission on Human Rights and widow of a former US president, was the person most responsible for getting the Declaration approved.



Eleanor Roosevelt



Amnesty symbol

Amnesty International

Set up in 1961, Amnesty International is a global pressure group, which campaigns for the release of people "detained anywhere for their beliefs, colour, sex, ethnic origin, language, or religion".

The European Court ruled against corporal punishment in schools.



European Court of Human Rights

The European Court, which meets in Strasbourg, France, exists to hear human rights cases from the whole of Europe. Individuals can bring cases against their government if they believe their human rights are threatened.

Rigoberta Menchu

Guatemalan human rights activist Rigoberta Menchu (b.1959) has campaigned since she was a teenager to secure and protect the rights of the native people in her country, who have been oppressed by Guatemala's military rulers. Menchu's own parents and brother were killed by the security forces. She was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1992 for her work.



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